

Slow-Cooker Mushroom Biryani

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SERVES 4 TO 6
COOKING TIME 2 to 3 hours on high

WHY THIS RECIPE WORKS Biryani uses fragrant long-grain basmati rice, enriching it with fresh herbs and pungent spices. Most recipes steep whole spices and cook each part of the dish separately before marrying them. Our streamlined, hands-free slow cooker version delivers on big, bold flavors without the fuss. We chose basmati rice for its nutty flavor and perfume-like aroma. Indian-inspired aromatics were first bloomed with oil in the microwave to jump-start flavor development. We then combined the bloomed spice blend, rice, and hot vegetable broth in our slow cooker before topping the rice with earthy mushrooms. Layering the mushrooms on top of the rice mixture ensured even cooking of the rice. We found that basmati rice cooked best on high. Placing a piece of parchment paper over the mixture prevented the grains on top from drying out as the water was absorbed and promoted even steaming in the rice. We added fresh spinach, herbs, and raisins before serving. Biryani is traditionally served with a cooling yogurt sauce; make it before starting the biryani to allow the flavors to meld. We prefer the flavor of basmati rice in this recipe, but long-grain white rice can be substituted. For more information on creating a parchment shield, see page 401. You will need a 5- to 7-quart oval slow cooker for this recipe. This recipe will only work in a traditional slow cooker.

SAUCE

- ¾ cup plain yogurt
- 2 tablespoons chopped fresh cilantro
- 2 tablespoons chopped fresh mint
- 1 garlic clove, minced

BIRYANI

- 1 onion, chopped fine
- 3 tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 teaspoons garam masala
- 1 teaspoon table salt
- ½ teaspoon turmeric
- ⅛ teaspoon cayenne pepper
- 1½ cups vegetable broth
- 1½ cups basmati rice, rinsed
- 1 pound cremini mushrooms, trimmed and sliced thin
- 6 ounces (6 cups) baby spinach, chopped coarse
- ¼ cup raisins
- 2 tablespoons chopped fresh cilantro
- 2 tablespoons chopped fresh mint
- ⅓ cup sliced almonds, toasted

1. **FOR THE SAUCE** Combine all ingredients in bowl and season with salt and pepper to taste. Refrigerate until ready to serve.

2. **FOR THE BIRYANI** Lightly coat slow cooker with vegetable oil spray. Microwave onion, oil, garlic, garam masala, salt, turmeric, and cayenne in bowl, stirring occasionally, until onion is softened, about 5 minutes; transfer to prepared slow cooker.

3. Microwave broth in bowl until steaming, about 5 minutes. Stir broth and rice into slow cooker. Spread mushrooms evenly on top of rice mixture. Gently press 16 by 12-inch sheet of parchment paper onto surface of mushrooms, folding down edges as needed. Cover and cook until rice is tender and all broth is absorbed, 2 to 3 hours on high.

4. Discard parchment. Sprinkle spinach and raisins on top of rice, cover, and let sit until spinach is wilted, about 5 minutes. Add cilantro and mint and fluff rice with fork until combined. Season with salt and pepper to taste. Sprinkle with almonds and serve, passing sauce separately.

PER SERVING **Cal** 320; **Total Fat** 11g, **Sat Fat** 2g; **Chol** 5mg; **Sodium** 620mg; **Total Carb** 48g, **Dietary Fiber** 2g, **Total Sugars** 10g; **Protein** 8g